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By Tommaso Lecca · Oct 14, 2026, 4:27 PM · View in your browser

Portugal’s government has chosen Lufthansa over Air France-KLM to become a major shareholder in TAP Air Portugal, it announced Wednesday.

The German airline group’s offer was preferred over that of its Franco-Dutch rival because Lufthansa “presented an ambitious growth plan for TAP and the possibility of new investments in Portugal,” the government said in a statement .

In addition, Lufthansa’s bid to acquire up to 49.9% of TAP was “up to 16% higher than that presented by Air France-KLM,” the government said.

Lisbon’s green light allows Lufthansa to buy a 44.9% stake in the Portuguese flag carrier. The German group could acquire an additional 5% if workers do not exercise their purchase rights. The sale is expected to generate €1.2 billion for the Portuguese state.

The Portuguese government will retain 50.1% of TAP’s shares, “preserving the control of the company and potential future appreciation of its participation,” it said.

The acquisition still requires approval from EU competition authorities.

The sale is part of a broader consolidation drive in European aviation, which in recent years has included Lufthansa’s deal with ITA Airways and Air France-KLM’s expansion into SAS Scandinavian Airlines.

Lufthansa’s subsidiaries include SWISS, Austrian Airlines and Brussels Airlines. Adding TAP to its portfolio would give the German group access to several destinations in Brazil.

Lisbon’s latest attempt to privatize the airline follows two unsuccessful attempts to sell stakes, in 1998 and 2015, after which the state eventually regained full control of the carrier.

The privatization “allows the recovery of the investment of €3,200 million injected by Portuguese taxpayers into the company in the last decade,” the government said.

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